

Privacy as Boundary and Pretext in Concealing Parallel Relationships

A reflective essay drawn from five conversations about digitally mediated relationships

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ABSTRACT

This essay draws on five conversations the author had with people who had been through serious conflict in relationships conducted largely through digital media. It is not a study. The conversations were not recorded and no notes were kept, so what follows is the author's recollection written up afterwards, and no direct quotation appears anywhere. What is examined is not having more than one partner but keeping it hidden: controlling the story, closing off access to information, and leaving the emotional work to the person being deceived. Three of the five described doing the hiding, two described being on the receiving end. Read side by side, the accounts repeat five things, from trust being built to trust breaking down. Only one ordering claim is made: concealment follows trust rather than preceding it. The central observation concerns how people explain a door they have closed. One called their use of privacy a wall they knew stopped questions; another called it a long-standing habit whose concealing effect they had not noticed. The essay cannot say which account is accurate, since its own argument is that people in this position shape their stories. It argues instead that both make the same move: they turn attention away from responsibility, one by claiming injury, the other by claiming unawareness.

Keywords: information control; concealment of parallel relationships; communication privacy management; liquid relationships; computer-mediated communication

1. INTRODUCTION

The way people conduct relationships has changed a great deal over the past few decades. Relationships today feel more fluid: easier to begin, easier to end, and often without binding commitment. The sociologist Zygmunt Bauman (2003) called this condition liquid love, meaning a state in which human bonds become loose and easily assembled and taken apart. The shift has been thorough enough that many people no longer find it strange.

Within that atmosphere one pattern stands out: conducting more than one relationship at the same time. This essay calls it a parallel relationship. It should be clear from the start what is being examined and what is not. Where everyone involved knows and agrees, that falls outside this discussion. What is discussed here is the situation in which one party does not know, and that not-knowing is deliberately maintained. Nor does this essay claim the pattern is becoming more common. Five cases are far too few to measure anything of that kind. All that can be done is to look at how the pattern works when it appears.

This is where digital space comes in. Through instant messaging and social media, a person can separate communication channels, control when they reply, and give different versions of a story to different people. Such a space is called CMC, short for Computer-

Mediated Communication, meaning communication that takes place through digital technology such as chat applications and social media (Walther & Parks, 2002).

The justification that appeared most often in these accounts is a word that sounds entirely reasonable: privacy. Once a partner begins asking further questions, the answer “that is my privacy” is enough to stop them. Privacy, which ought to be a healthy right, becomes a door that has been closed. What is interesting, and this is what the essay contributes, is how people explained that door afterwards. Some explained it as a choice; one explained it as a habit they had not been aware of. This essay cannot establish which explanation is true. But both explanations turn out to do the same work, and that is precisely where the observation lies.

One sentence about the title belongs here, so that it is not misread. The title calls privacy a boundary and a pretext. What that names is two things the word can do, as set out in Section 2.2, not two kinds of people who can be told apart. This essay in fact declines to sort people that way, and the reason is given in Section 4.3.

From that gap, this essay moves toward three questions:

1. How does a pattern of concealing parallel relationships survive inside a relationship?
2. How far is the person doing the concealing aware of its effects, and what keeps the pattern running?
3. How does the affected party respond once they begin to sense something is wrong?

The main lens used here is information control, meaning the way a person manages what others are allowed to know, who is allowed to know it, and which version of the story reaches whom. What makes this pattern manipulative is not the fact of having more than one relationship. What is manipulative is the concealing of it, the managing of the story, and the shifting of the burden onto the person being deceived. This is not a judgement of any particular person. It is a way of naming a pattern that recurs across these accounts.

2. BACKGROUND

2.1 The Normative Climate: Fluid Relationships

Bauman (2003) argued that contemporary bonds have become fragile and provisional. People want to stay connected but are reluctant to be tied down too deeply. Anthony Giddens (1992) described something adjacent through the terms pure relationship and confluent love. A modern relationship, on this account, is sustained for as long as it remains mutually satisfying and can be ended at any time by either party. Because it is conditional in that way, fidelity shifts from an absolute obligation to something negotiable. Eva Illouz (2007) added a further layer through emotional capitalism: market reasoning enters emotional life, so that relationships can be weighed as profit and loss and closeness can be treated as a resource.

These three ideas are used here only to describe the atmosphere, not as the main analytic tool. One qualification matters. The ideal of a fluid relationship between equals often fails to match reality. [Jamieson \(1999\)](#) showed that personal life remains heavily structured by inequality, so fluidity does not benefit everyone equally. An application of these ideas to dating applications can be found in [Hobbs, Owen, and Gerber \(2017\)](#).

2.2 The Main Framework: Communication Privacy Management

The main analytic tool in this essay is CPM, short for Communication Privacy Management ([Petronio, 2002](#)). The core idea is simple. Every person draws a kind of boundary around their private information, then makes rules about who may know and who may not. As long as those rules are fair and agreed, privacy is a healthy and ordinary thing.

The problem arises when that boundary is used not to protect a reasonable private space but to conceal something from a person who ought to know. At that point privacy becomes three things at once. It protects a particular version of the story, it obstructs anyone trying to verify, and it closes off access to matters that genuinely bear on the relationship.

There is a gap in CPM worth highlighting, because that is where this essay adds something. CPM explains in detail how boundary rules are built, negotiated and broken. What it says almost nothing about is what happens afterwards: how a person narrates their own boundary rule once that rule has harmed someone else and they are asked to account for it. That narration is not merely a report. It is part of the conduct, and these accounts suggest such narration has a recognisable shape. A shorter overview of CPM can be found in [Petronio and Durham \(2015\)](#).

Recent work has begun to open that stage. [Amirkhani, Alizadeh, Gerami, Randall, and Stevens \(2026\)](#) interviewed couples about how they manage privacy on their phones and found that much of it is never discussed at all. They call this privacy silence: the deliberate avoidance of conversations about privacy. Among the reasons partners gave for leaving boundaries unspoken were an assumption that boundaries would be respected without being stated, and a sense that raising the subject would itself signal distrust. That finding matters here for two reasons. It shows that boundary rules genuinely can go unexamined rather than being strategically designed, which makes one account in this essay more plausible than it would otherwise be. And it marks where this essay sits: their concern is the silence itself, while the concern here is what happens when that silence is finally broken and its owner has to explain it.

2.3 Why the Digital Medium Lowers the Friction

Several features of digital space make concealment easier to sustain. [Walther \(2007\)](#) describes selective self-presentation, the ability to choose which side of oneself to display, with greater control than is available face to face. Long before that, Erving [Goffman \(1959\)](#) had shown that

everyone manages how they appear before others, like an actor on a stage. The difference is that in digital space this management can be done far more neatly, because there is no pressure to answer on the spot. [Suler \(2004\)](#) adds that people tend to be less inhibited online, which he called the online disinhibition effect.

Digital space also makes compartmentalisation easier, meaning the separation of one relationship from another so that they do not collide. Research on online deception is relevant here. [Hancock, Thom-Santelli, and Ritchie \(2004\)](#) found that forms of lying differ across media. [Toma and Hancock \(2012\)](#) showed that how people write can leave certain traces when they are concealing something. On online infidelity specifically, [Whitty \(2005\)](#) showed that involvement with another person through an online medium can be experienced by a partner as genuine betrayal, even though the line between what counts as a violation is often blurred. At the correlational level, [Abbasi and Dibble \(2025\)](#) report an association between social media addiction and behaviours tending toward infidelity, with the caveat that the statistical moderation in their findings requires careful interpretation. On scale, [Warach, Bornstein, Gorman, and Moyer \(2024\)](#) pooled 305 studies covering more than half a million respondents across 47 countries and put electronic infidelity at around 18 per cent, against 17.5 per cent for sexual and 27 per cent for emotional infidelity. Work of that kind is what it takes to say anything about how common something is, and it is worth naming here precisely because this essay makes no such claim.

One further line of work bears directly on what happens to the person left in the dark. [Bai, Fu, and Van Swol \(2024\)](#) studied interpersonal electronic surveillance, meaning the covert checking of a partner through digital means, and framed it as a way of managing uncertainty rather than as simple jealousy. On their account, people begin monitoring when uncertainty grows past what they can tolerate and they see no other route to reducing it. That framing will matter in Section 4.8, where one of the accounts here ends in exactly that place.

2.4 Trust: How It Forms and How It Breaks

The pattern examined here always begins with trust, so it is worth understanding first where trust comes from. [Mayer, Davis, and Schoorman \(1995\)](#) identify three components: ability, benevolence, and integrity. They also use the term willingness to be vulnerable, meaning the state in which a person is prepared to take a risk because they feel sufficiently confident. That is exactly where the difficulty sits. Once trust is high, vigilance drops, and small things that do not fit tend to be excused. [Yum and Hara \(2005\)](#) add that trust in digital space forms gradually through accumulated disclosure, so that when it collapses the impact is heavy.

2.5 The Limits of This Framework in an Indonesian Setting

All the frameworks above were developed in Europe and North America, while the people who told these stories are in Indonesia. That difference cannot be treated lightly. The idea of fluid

relationships presupposes considerable personal freedom and loose social oversight. Yet in many Indonesian settings, romantic relationships involve extended family, tight friendship circles, and religious norms. Ending a relationship is therefore not a matter for two people alone.

It is possible that what looks like fluidity is in fact working through a different route. Not because bonds have weakened, but because digital space provides somewhere that escapes a social oversight which remains tight offline. This essay is not designed to test that possibility. The frameworks above are therefore used as reading tools of limited reach, not as tested explanations for an Indonesian setting. Testing them across settings remains open work.

3. WHAT THIS ESSAY RESTS ON

3.1 What Kind of Writing This Is

This is not a research report. There was no designed data collection, no recording, and no field notes. What exists is five face-to-face conversations the author took part in, then remembered, then wrote down. The closest genre is the reflective essay: writing that arranges the author's own experience in order to bring out patterns worth thinking about further. It can propose ideas; it cannot prove them. Wherever this essay sounds like it is concluding, read it as proposing.

The codes P1 to P5 are used to protect the confidentiality of those who spoke, but they should not be read as participant codes in a study. These people were not recruited. They are people who talked with the author and agreed that their accounts could be used.

3.2 The Five People Who Spoke

Five people were approached deliberately because they fit the theme, not selected at random. There were two conditions. First, they had been through a significant relational conflict within the past two years, with most of the communication taking place through digital text. Second, they were willing to speak openly. All were between 22 and 30 years old with undergraduate education.

All five came from the author's personal network. This is practical for a topic that is hard to raise with strangers, but the consequence must be stated. They come from adjacent social circles, so their backgrounds and outlooks may be more uniform than if they had been found through an open call. Other details such as gender, occupation, place of residence, and relationship duration are deliberately not reported. There are few of them and they know the author personally, so a combination of such details could make them identifiable within their own social circles.

Their positions are deliberately not fixed. P1, P2, and P5 mostly spoke as the party doing the concealing. P3 and P4 mostly spoke as the party affected by it. But the line between the two is often fluid, and some spoke from both sides across different relationships. The terms

perpetrator and victim are not used in this essay. In their place, the essay uses the party concealing and the party affected, because the first pair carries a judgement that is not intended and that the basis of this essay cannot support.

3.3 The Author's Position

The author knew some of these people personally before these conversations took place. That closeness is why they were willing to talk about things that are hard to tell a stranger. Much of what appears in this essay would probably never have surfaced had the person asking been someone they did not know.

But that closeness also carries three risks, and all three need to be stated plainly. First, consent becomes less free, because refusing a friend is harder than refusing a stranger. Second, the author's interpretation may be shaped by what the author already knew about them and about the people in their accounts. Third, the risk of their being identified is higher, because a reader in the same social circle could guess from details that look small. The third risk is addressed by withholding the demographic reporting described above. The first two cannot be eliminated.

There is one further matter that must be declared, and it is the least comfortable. One of those who spoke had at some point shown the author part of a digital conversation between themselves and their partner, outside the context of this essay. That material was not collected as source material, is not quoted, was not analysed, and will never be used, because the other party to that conversation was never asked for permission and was in no position to give it.

The author has nonetheless already read it, and it would not be honest to claim that reading had no effect. Part of the author's understanding of one case may have been formed there rather than from the conversation alone, and after this interval the author can no longer separate the two with confidence. Readers should take that into account, particularly in passages describing the conduct of people who were never spoken to. For any future writing, material of that kind is better not looked at in the first place, precisely so as not to create a problem like this one.

3.4 How These Conversations Became This Essay

The five conversations took place face to face between early April and early June 2026. None took place by telephone, video call, or text message. Each lasted between 45 and 80 minutes. They followed wherever the person's account led, although the author tried to reach four things: the conflict they had experienced, how trust changed over time, patterns that felt repetitive, and how they responded when what they sensed did not match what the other person was saying.

What happened afterwards determines the weight of everything here. The conversations were not recorded, and the author wrote nothing down either during them or immediately

afterwards. The contents were assembled from memory, written down later when the author began organising his thinking.

Three consequences have to be accepted as they are. Not a single original sentence survives, so this essay contains no direct quotation and never can. Memory is also not a recording: it reconstructs, compresses, and tends to tidy an account toward whatever already makes sense to the person remembering, so the similarities reported in Section 4 may in part have arisen from how the author remembers. And there is no material anyone can re-examine, including the author. The reader is ultimately asked to trust one person's memory.

This essay also collected no archive of digital conversation as source material. There are no screenshots, no chat exports, and no access to anyone's device or account. The limitation concerning material the author saw outside the context of this essay is stated in Section 3.3.

3.5 How the Material Was Organised

The material was organised by writing down what the author remembered of each conversation, reading it repeatedly, marking what recurred, and grouping it. The procedure was inspired by thematic analysis as set out by [Braun and Clarke \(2006\)](#), but it would not be honest to call it an application of that method. Thematic analysis works on raw data, and this essay has no raw data. What was coded was not anyone's speech but the author's own writing about what he remembered.

The flow ran roughly as follows. A recollection that someone closed off every question by invoking privacy was marked as closing-the-question. That marker, together with refusing-to-name-the-incident and admitting-only-in-general-terms, was grouped into a larger cluster about controlling access to information. That cluster was then split again once it became clear that two people explained something similar in very different ways.

The organising was done by the author alone. There was no second coder, and the result was not checked back with those who had spoken. The second of these is in fact the easiest to do and the most valuable, since it is the only way to ensure the author's recollection has not drifted from what the person meant. Not doing it is a real weakness, and one that is entirely fixable next time.

3.6 Ethics

The topic is sensitive and involves people who were not present in these conversations, so the ethical considerations need to be set out openly, including those that were not met.

Institutional ethics review. This essay was produced independently without institutional affiliation, so it did not pass through any ethics committee. That absence is stated openly and is not treated as trivial. In its place, several safeguards were applied as described below, and readers are invited to judge for themselves whether they suffice.

Consent. All five gave their consent verbally, after being told the purpose of this essay, how their accounts would be used, and the plan to publish. They were told that taking part was voluntary and could be stopped at any time without consequence. No written consent document was signed. All of them made one condition, which the author accepted as binding: their names must not appear, and their identities must be disguised. That condition is the basis for the use of the codes P1 to P5 and for the decision to withhold demographic reporting described in Section 3.2. Verbal consent is weaker than written consent, particularly for a topic that could harm the person telling the story.

Third parties. These accounts unavoidably involve other people: partners, former partners, and others in the parallel relationships. They were never spoken to and could not give consent. All identifying markers that appeared have been disguised. Even so, it must be acknowledged that this essay still conveys a picture of people who were never given a chance to respond. For that reason the essay refrains from judging their motives, and every statement about a person who was not spoken to is written as the perception of the person telling the story, not as fact.

Disclosures that carry risk for the teller. Some disclosed things that could harm them if their circle knew, including admitting to using relationships for particular gains. Such material is reported only as far as is needed to support the observation, held back at the level of detail that could lead to identification, and not accompanied by any moral judgement of the individual concerned.

Handling of material. No material of any kind was sent to an artificial intelligence service or a third-party cloud service. The organising was done manually by the author. That decision was taken precisely because this essay is about control over private information. Moving other people's accounts onto a commercial service would contradict the very matter under discussion.

Comfort during the conversations. The author was prepared to pause or stop if the other person appeared uncomfortable, and they were told they could skip any question without giving a reason.

3.7 Limitations

The most decisive limitation is the nature of the material, as set out in Section 3.4. Whatever is written here is therefore not offered as a research finding. Beyond that there are several further limitations.

They run as follows. There are only five people, approached deliberately, all from the author's personal network, so nothing here can be generalised to any wider group. All the accounts are retrospective, recalled after the events had passed, and therefore already shaped by interpretation and the distance of time. The accounts are also available from one side of the relationship only, even though one of this essay's central arguments concerns an ambiguity

that cannot be read from one side. Organising by one person without a second reader leaves room for bias. Finally, the connection drawn between digital media and this pattern is interpretive, since there is no comparison with relationships conducted face to face.

4. WHAT RECURS ACROSS THE FIVE ACCOUNTS

4.1 How to Read What Follows

When the five accounts are set side by side, striking similarities appear. From that comparison five phases were assembled: (1) trust forms, checking relaxes; (2) information control; (3) conduct at odds with the account; (4) treated as ordinary; and (5) trust collapses.

One caveat governs how much may be taken from what follows. No single case here was traced whole from phase 1 to phase 5. These five phases are an aggregate of five accounts, not a path one person travelled from beginning to end.

This essay makes one claim about ordering, and only one. Concealment comes after trust has formed, not before it. That claim is supported by two independent accounts. P1 described their early involvement as genuine, with the latitude arriving only once trust had formed. P3 described themselves as not suspicious at the outset, beginning to look for evidence only after something started to feel wrong. Beyond that single claim, the ordering between phases is not supported by this material. The later phases may well interweave, recur, or appear together. So apart from that one claim, the word phase here is simply a device for arranging the reading. A reader looking for a tested stage model will not find one here.

Table 1. Five Phases in the Concealment of Parallel Relationships

Phase	Name	What Happens	From	Detail
1	Trust forms, checking relaxes	Early attention builds safety, and safety makes checking feel unnecessary.	P1, P3, P4	General
2	Information control	Access and the story are managed; privacy closes down questions.	P1, P2, P5	Specific: mechanics
3	Conduct at odds with the account	Behaviour changes, and the change does not fit what is said.	P4	Specific: trigger
4	Treated as ordinary	The pattern is treated as ordinary for a time, through two different mechanisms.	P1 to P5	General
5	Trust collapses	Suspicion leads to checking, or the relationship ends. Both routes taken alone.	P3, P4	Specific: trigger

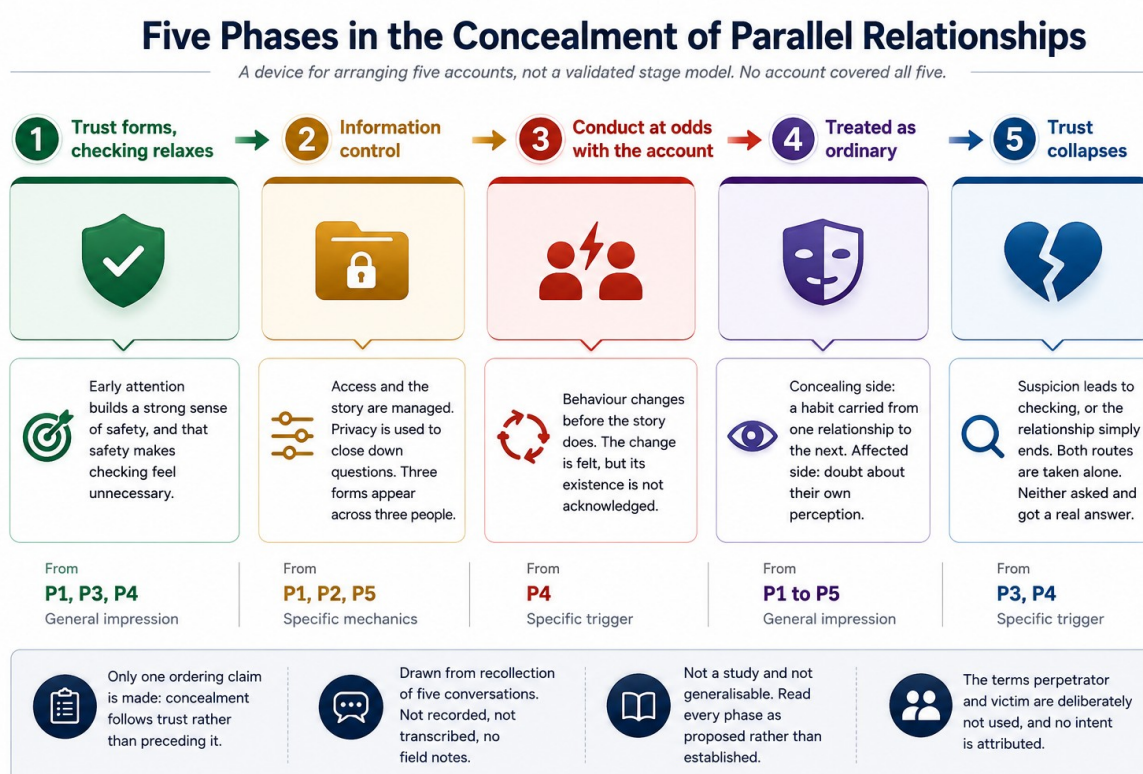


Figure 1. Five phases in the concealment of parallel relationships

The detail-level column in the table shows which phases are supported by specific accounts of concrete mechanics and which rest only on general impressions. Two phases, the first and the fourth, rest only on general impressions. Both stand more weakly than the other three.

4.2 Phase 1: Trust Forms, Checking Relaxes

The relationships described generally began with a phase they characterised as very good: intense attention, a sense of full presence, and an openness that seemed genuine. This is the phase that builds a sense of safety, and that safety gradually reduces the felt need to check on the part of the person who will later be affected.

From the concealing side, what the author recalls of P1's account is that this early attention was not described as a tactic. P1 said their involvement had genuinely been wholehearted at first, and that the trust which formed from it was something they only later realised had given them latitude. The order matters. The latitude arrived as a consequence of trust genuinely forming, not as an aim planned from the start.

From the affected side, P4 described a sense of safety so settled in the early phase that it did not occur to them that anything needed questioning. It was precisely that settledness which later made small changes hard to recognise as changes.

P3 described the same thing from the side of its effect. P3 trusted their partner completely and felt no need to check anything, because to their mind there was nothing that needed

checking. That is exactly where the room for concealment opens. When nobody is checking, a great deal can be managed without being noticed.

Trust and the relaxing of checking are deliberately placed in one phase rather than two, because they say very nearly the same thing. In the framework of [Mayer et al. \(1995\)](#), trust is defined as a willingness to be vulnerable to risk, which already contains the lowering of vigilance. It should be noted that this phase rests only on general impressions from three people, with no specific account of any event that marked it.

4.3 Phase 2: Information Control

This phase carries more detail than any other. Once checking has relaxed, information begins to be actively managed. That management appeared in three different forms across three people, and the differences between them matter more than what they share.

First form: managed separation

P1 was conducting two relationships at once: a current partner and a former partner with whom the relationship continued. The two were kept from colliding through a simple separation of time: seeing one today, the other tomorrow. What was being controlled was not the people directly but the information, namely what could be known, by whom, and in which version of the story.

What the author recalls of P1's account names three methods working together. First, managing traces. P1 described themselves as adept at hiding conversations and removing anything that could become a marker. Second, handling the situation when the concealment failed. According to P1, even once discovered, the situation could still be turned by placing themselves as the one who had been hurt, so that the discussion shifted from what they had done to how they were feeling. Third, settling the person asking. When the former partner raised the question of their standing, P1 recalls answering with a message whose substance was that what mattered was that the two of them were still together.

This third method is the most interesting. An answer like that sounds like an answer. There is affirmation, there is reassurance. But it contains nothing that can be checked. It closes the question without actually answering it. The same pattern appears in how P1 described themselves during conflict: the form meets social expectation, but the centre of the account shifts from what they did to how difficult their own situation was.

All of the above comes from P1's own account. No conversation archive was examined and nobody else in that relationship was spoken to, so what is reported is how P1 narrated that management, not how it actually proceeded.

Second form: privacy as a way of closing questions

P2 was conducting one official relationship alongside another behind it, and their main instrument was the word privacy. Whenever a partner probed further, invoking privacy was enough to close the door on inquiry. But P2's own account resists being read as deliberate tactics.

As the author recalls it, P2 said that their guarding of privacy was not because there was something to hide, at least according to what they believed at the time, but because there was a part of themselves they did not want to be too visible. P2 also said they had not been fully aware that this habit affected how their partner judged their honesty.

The largest temptation here is to conclude that there are therefore two mechanisms of concealment, one deliberate and one not. That conclusion must not be drawn, and the reason comes from this essay's own argument.

This essay holds that people in the position of concealing shape their accounts so as to appear better, and P1 is even described as adept at turning a situation by placing themselves as the injured party. If that is right, P2's account of their own unawareness is exactly the kind of account one would expect, since someone concealing deliberately and someone concealing without realising both have strong reason to tell it that way. So the account cannot separate those two possibilities. What differs is not the mechanism but the telling, and that difference is itself observable. Section 4.7 takes up what it does.

P2 also said that admitting fault in general terms felt far lighter than naming a particular incident. Admitting to being simply that kind of person is easy. Naming exactly what happened felt like handing over control of a story they had been guarding. Admitting only in general terms without naming any concrete event accords with what [Dailey and Palomares \(2004\)](#) call topic avoidance. It must be stressed that avoidance of this kind cannot be distinguished from simple difficulty in finding words on the basis of its form alone, still less on material consisting of recollected summaries as here. That judgement rests on the author's impression during the conversation.

Third form: relationships as a resource

P5 spoke openly about conducting several relationships at once. At one period P5 was in intensive contact with around four people, drawing on them for practical gains: material things, access, and social networks. P5 described that closeness as something managed rather than something that simply happened.

Of the three forms in this section, P5's account names mechanics most specifically, and those mechanics are the most distinctively digital. Four methods were described as working together: separating time, arranging matters so that no two people were met on the same day; separating place, so that different social circles would not intersect; separating devices, using different phones for different people; and deleting conversation traces periodically.

Of those four, only the first two could be done without digital technology. Using separate phones and deleting traces have no direct equivalent in a relationship conducted face to face, since both require a record that can be separated and erased. This is the single account across all this material that most supports the claim that digital media make concealment easier. It should be noted that it rests on one person only.

Two qualifications are needed. First, P5 stated that not all of these relationships were romantic; some were described as friendships. That case is therefore not fully parallel with the others and cannot be treated as a complete instance of a romantic parallel relationship. Second, nobody in P5's network was spoken to. How the pattern was experienced by them, whether as betrayal, as absence, or not at all, lies entirely beyond the reach of this material.

4.4 Phase 3: Conduct at Odds with the Account

Over time, neat management begins to leave gaps. What is interesting is that in these accounts the first gap detected was not an inconsistency in the story but a change in conduct.

P4 described the first thing they felt as distance. Their partner came to feel different: present but not fully, responses changed, and there was something P4 called a sense of distance they could not immediately name. That change in conduct did not fit the account their partner was giving, and the mismatch between what they sensed and what was being said is what slowly accumulated.

This ordering means something. The affected party in these accounts did not begin to suspect because they found evidence, nor because they caught an obvious lie. They began to suspect because they sensed a change whose very existence was not acknowledged. The trouble is that a sense of distance is a weak basis on which to raise an objection. It can be broken simply by saying you are overthinking it. This is where doubt about one's own perception begins to grow, and from there comes the need to find something more solid than a feeling.

4.5 Phase 4: Treated as Ordinary

Before anything comes apart, there is a phase in which an unhealthy pattern is treated as ordinary by both sides. The affected party begins to think perhaps this is normal, or perhaps I am overreacting. Meanwhile some of those doing the concealing described the pattern as a habit carried from one relationship to the next, almost never genuinely chosen.

What matters is that this normalisation works through two different mechanisms on the two sides. For the party concealing, the mechanism is habit. That is what they said themselves: the pattern carried over from one relationship to the next without ever really being chosen. It should be stressed that this mechanism is taken from what they said, not from theory. Not one of them connected their conduct to the norms of the age, to loosening commitment, or to a view that relationships are now more fluid. For that reason the idea of fluid relationships in Section

2.1 is left standing as background atmosphere only, and is not used to explain anyone's conduct here.

For the affected party the mechanism is entirely different. They treat it as ordinary not because they agree that relationships may be loose, but because confidence in their own perception gradually erodes. That self-doubt is what keeps them there.

The difference matters practically. It means that stopping normalisation requires two different things. On the concealing side, what is needed is a re-examination of a rule that has never been examined. On the affected side, what is needed is the restoration of confidence in their own perception. If the two are simply treated alike as both finding it ordinary, the difference is covered over. It should be noted that this phase was assembled from summaries across conversations without specific detail, so its basis is weaker than the other phases even though its content is the most promising.

One further point. This habit that is never examined is in fact the same mechanism as the one appearing with P2, namely a privacy boundary carried along without ever being reviewed. So these are not two observations but one observation surfacing in two places. In line with the critique from [Jamieson \(1999\)](#), what is clear in this material is that looseness of rules does not benefit both sides equally. The one who benefits is the person whose rules nobody has ever examined.

4.6 Phase 5: Trust Collapses

Trust rarely collapses in a single event. It erodes slowly, then breaks. P3's turning point came when they opened their partner's device, and from there the parallel relationship came apart. What matters is that P3 was not suspicious from the beginning. P3 only looked for evidence after a pattern began to feel wrong. This reinforces the point that concealment develops after trust has formed, not before.

P4 described a different route. No device was opened and no evidence was found all at once. What happened was a gradual reading of a change in conduct that kept going, until P4 concluded on their own that the relationship could not continue, and ended it. It later emerged that their partner had indeed been involved with someone else, a person who had been part of that partner's life before the relationship with P4 began.

What stands out most in P4's account is what they did throughout that time: they protected the person who was harming them. P4 covered up things that would have made their partner look bad, including harsh speech and difficult outbursts of temper. P4 maintained that partner's image before others and worked to defuse conflict, precisely during the period when they themselves were hurting. Their affection for their partner is described as having remained strong throughout.

This pattern reveals the least visible thing in all this material. The person being hurt carries emotional labour that ought to be someone else's responsibility, and at the same time carries the work of maintaining that person's good name before their circle. That work goes unseen precisely because it succeeds. Nobody around them ever knows there was anything to see.

The picture of the conduct of P4's partner comes entirely from P4's account. That person was not spoken to and had no opportunity to respond, so it is reported as P4's perception, not as verified statement.

Their routes differ: one ended in checking that produced evidence, the other in a conclusion drawn without evidence and confirmed only later. But there is a more important similarity, and it is what answers the third question of this essay. Both acted alone. P3 checked in secret, P4 concluded alone and left. Neither is reported as having asked directly and received an answer that genuinely explained anything.

This is not a matter of character. Asking directly had already been closed off by the concealment itself, through the answers set out in Section 4.3. So when the affected party finally senses something is wrong, the door to clearing it up together is no longer there. What remains are the one-sided routes: check in secret, or leave. The answer is therefore not a list of reactions but a statement about their shape. The response is unilateral, because concealment has already used up the alternatives.

4.7 Two Ways of Explaining the Same Door

The main contribution of this essay is not the discovery of two kinds of concealment. As explained in Section 4.3, this material cannot separate the deliberate from the unwitting. Its contribution sits one level above that, on something genuinely observable: how people explain a door they have already closed.

Two ways appear, both from people who equally admitted to concealing. P1 explains it as a choice; P2 explains it as a habit whose concealing effect they only realised later.

At first glance the two are opposites. One admits awareness, the other denies it. But if one attends to what each account does, they turn out to do the same thing. P1 has a way of shifting attention from what they did to the state they were in, by placing themselves as the injured party. P2 shifts attention through a different door, by stating that they did not know their conduct had an effect. One uses injury, the other uses unawareness. The result is the same: what stands at the centre of the discussion is no longer what happened to the other person.

It is worth being explicit about what is not being said here. This essay does not accuse P2 of lying. That account may well be accurate as given. What is being said is that the account, true or not, does a particular piece of work within the conversation in which it is uttered. And that work can be observed without guessing at anyone's inner state.

This is where the gap in CPM lies (Petronio, 2002). CPM explains in detail how people build boundary rules, negotiate them, and break them. What it says almost nothing about is the stage that follows, when the boundary rule has already harmed someone and its owner is asked to account for it. At that stage, the boundary rule becomes material for a story. This material suggests such stories have a recognisable shape, and that shape tends to move responsibility away from the person telling it.

This formulation also answers the second question of this essay differently from what was initially expected. The question was how far the person concealing is aware of the effects. The honest answer is that this essay cannot measure anyone's awareness. What can be reported is that awareness itself becomes material that can be managed in the telling. Claiming not to have been aware is not only a report about an inner state. It is also a move.

The formulation rests on recollection of two accounts, so it is offered as a proposition worth testing rather than a settled conclusion. How to test it is clear: interview both sides of the same relationship, record them, and compare how each narrates the same door.

4.8 Asymmetry of Knowledge About Channels

One pattern in this material concerns digital media in a more specific way than the general observation that concealing has become easier. It is best begun by correcting an assumption that often appears: that the person concealing can delete traces, while the affected party has no traces at all.

That assumption is wrong for a channel used by two people. In any chat application, both parties hold their own copy. If one person deletes a conversation on their phone, the copy on the other person's phone remains intact. So on the matter of retaining a record, the two sides are in fact equal.

The imbalance lies elsewhere, and its location is more decisive. The affected party has full access to the channels they know about, and no access at all to the channels they do not know exist. What the concealing party controls is not the archive but the knowledge of which channels there are. P5 described this most clearly: different phones for different people. What is separated there is not the content of the conversations but the existence of those conversations.

This distinction matters because it is where the digital specificity actually lies. A relationship conducted in the physical world involves a body that has to be somewhere, time that gets used up, and other people who happen to see. All of that leaves something to be suspicious about. A conversation on a phone whose existence is unknown leaves nothing. There is nothing to examine, because nobody knows there is anything to examine.

The consequence shows in what the affected party had to resort to. P4 began to sense a change not from a record they could re-read but from a shift in conduct they could not show to

anyone. P3 obtained something solid only after opening their partner's device, an act that crossed a boundary and was taken precisely because there was no other route. Both faced a choice in which both options were bad: trust their own perception without anything to hold on to, or cross someone else's boundary in order to have something to hold on to.

This supplements the idea in [Yum and Hara \(2005\)](#) that trust in digital space forms gradually through accumulated disclosure. What appears here is that the accumulation may never have been as complete as it seemed, and one party has no way of knowing. The part that most supports it comes from one person only.

4.9 Practical Implications, and One Warning About Them

Because the two ways of telling cannot be used to work out what actually happened, the affected party cannot rely on the other person's admission in order to assess their situation. Hearing that is just how I am or I did not realise tells you nothing about how deliberate the conduct was. Only one thing can be assessed, and it is the most practical one: whether the question was answered or merely stopped.

The second implication concerns confidence in one's own perception. Phase 4 suggests that what keeps a person in place is not agreement with what is happening but doubt about whether they are entitled to feel that something is wrong. The most relevant support is therefore not to judge the relationship but to restore the standing of their own perception as a basis for judging.

The author has developed a web application called S.E.R.A (Smart Emotional Relationship Adviser) in response to the problem described here. It was not used in this essay in any form and contributed to none of the observations above. It is mentioned only because honesty requires it: the author has an interest in the idea that such a tool is useful, and readers are entitled to know. It has never been evaluated, and this essay offers no evidence about its usefulness.

Quite the opposite: one note from these conversations points the other way. One person reported that using a tool of that kind made their suspicion excessive. This is a serious warning, and its structure is dangerous: a tool built to help someone examine their own perception is most likely to be sought by someone whose confidence in that perception is already shaken, and that is precisely the state in which strengthening suspicion is hardest to distinguish from restoring sound judgement. Anyone building something similar, the author included, needs to reckon with that and test for it first.

4.10 What Cannot Be Concluded From This Essay

Several conclusions a reader might be tempted to draw are not supported by what this essay rests on. Most comprehensively: it does not show anything in the sense in which research shows things, since it has no instrument for proving. More specifically, this essay does not

show that the concealment of parallel relationships is becoming more common, since five accounts cannot measure a trend. It does not show that digital technology causes this conduct, since there is no comparison with relationships conducted face to face. It does not show that particular language patterns signal deception, since no original sentences survive to be examined. Nor does it show how the people who were never spoken to experienced these relationships, since they were never asked.

What this essay offers is one framework for reading and one conceptual distinction, both arising from one person's experience of listening to five others. Their value lies in whether they are useful to think with, not in whether they have been established. How to test them is clear and not difficult: interview both sides of the same relationship, record them, and compare how each narrates the same door.

5. CONCLUSION

This essay set out from a simple observation, that relationships today feel increasingly fluid. From there it narrowed to a sharper question: how the word privacy is used to conceal parallel relationships, and how that pattern comes to be treated as ordinary. Five people in different positions gave accounts that complement one another.

What they show was assembled as five phases: trust forming and checking relaxing, information control, conduct at odds with the account, being treated as ordinary for a time, and trust collapsing. The firm caveat is that no single case went through all five. Of those five phases this essay ventures only one claim about ordering: concealment grows after trust has formed, not before. Otherwise these phases are a way of arranging the reading, not a tested sequence of stages.

What most deserves carrying away from this essay concerns how people explain a door they have already closed. Two people who equally admitted to concealing explained it in opposite ways. One called it a choice; the other called it a habit they had not been aware of. This essay cannot establish which is true, and does not pretend it can, since its own argument holds that people in this position shape their accounts. What can be observed is that both accounts do the same thing. One shifts attention through injury, the other through unawareness, and both ensure that what stands at the centre of the discussion is no longer what happened to the other person. That is where the gap in CPM lies. The theory explains how boundary rules are built and broken, but says almost nothing about how those rules are narrated once they have harmed someone.

Normalisation likewise works through two different mechanisms. For the party concealing, the mechanism is habit, and that is taken from what they said themselves rather than from any theory of the age. For the affected party, what keeps them in place is not agreement but doubt about their own perception. The third question of this essay is answered at the same point. Both affected parties acted alone, one checking in secret and the other

concluding and leaving. Neither asked and received a genuine answer, because that route had already been closed off by the concealment.

On the role of digital media, this essay holds back. What can be said is not that technology causes this pattern, since there is no comparison with relationships conducted face to face. What can be said is narrower: for one person, the way they concealed required channels whose existence could be hidden, and channels of that kind are indeed more available in digital space. The affected party has full access to the channels they know about, and none to the channels they do not know exist. Beyond that, the connection between medium and pattern is inferred from theory, not from this material.

The limitations are set out in Section 3.7 and need only be summarised here: the material is recollection that nobody can re-examine, the accounts come from one side of the relationship only, and the organising was done by one person without a second reader. Further work would be considerably stronger with a larger and more varied group, with recorded and transcribed interviews, with both sides of the same relationship, and with change in trust followed over time. The questions of how normalisation can be interrupted, and how technology might become a space for repair rather than merely a store of conflict, await more systematic work.

STATEMENTS

Language versions. This work exists in English and Indonesian. The Indonesian version is titled “Privasi sebagai Batas dan Dalih dalam Penyembunyian Relasi Paralel”. Both versions present the same content and neither supersedes the other. Readers citing this work should cite the version they consulted and may note the existence of the other.

Funding. This work received no funding from any institution.

Conflict of interest. The author has developed S.E.R.A (Smart Emotional Relationship Adviser), a web application addressed to the problem discussed in this essay. That tool was not used in this work, neither as a data collection instrument nor as an analytic tool, and contributed to none of the observations reported. Its existence is declared here because the author has an interest in the premise that such a tool is useful, so that readers may weigh the possibility of bias. The author derives no commercial benefit from the tool at the time of writing, and this essay advances no evidence about its usefulness.

Ethics review. This work was carried out independently without institutional affiliation and did not pass through any ethics committee. The safeguards applied in its place are set out in Section 3.6.

Data availability. There is no data to share, because this work does not rest on a data set. The conversations underlying it were neither recorded nor written down, so there are no recordings, transcripts, or field notes that could be provided to anyone. This situation is described in Section 3.4.

Use of artificial intelligence. This work used no artificial intelligence assistance of any kind. Its material comes from direct conversation, and the organising was done manually by the author. This essay contains no verbatim quotation, and no account of any person was composed, completed, or reconstructed using a language model. All interpretation, analysis, and conclusions are the author's responsibility.

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